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Mesoamerica: Advanced Civilizations



Image: Cover for *Tales from La Vida*, Illustrated by Jason Gonzalez

A Brief Introduction

Make certain to take careful notes!

"*Avocado, tomato, and chocolate.* You are likely familiar with at least some of these food items. Did you know that they all originally come from Mexico, and are all based on Nahuatl words (*ahuacatl*, *tomatl*, and *chocolatl*) that were eventually adopted by the English language?"

"Nahuatl is the language spoken by the Nahua ethnic group that is found today in Mexico, but with deep historical roots. You might know one Nahua group: the Aztecs, more accurately called the Mexica. The Mexica were one of many Mesoamerican cultural groups that flourished in Mexico prior to the arrival of Europeans in the sixteenth century."

Where was Mesoamerica?

Mesoamerica refers to the diverse civilizations that shared similar cultural characteristics in the geographic areas comprising the modern-day countries of Mexico, Guatemala, Honduras, Belize, El Salvador, Nicaragua, and Costa Rica. Some of the shared cultural traits among Mesoamerican peoples included a

complex pantheon of deities, architectural features, a ballgame, the 260-day calendar, trade, food (especially a reliance on maize, beans, and squash), dress, and accoutrements (additional items that are worn or used by a person, such as earspools)."

"Some of the most well-known Mesoamerican cultures are the Olmec, Maya, Zapotec, Teotihuacan, Mixtec, and [Mexico \(or Aztec\)](https://smarthistory.org/aztec-mexica-an-introduction/) 

[\(https://smarthistory.org/aztec-mexica-an-introduction/\)](https://smarthistory.org/aztec-mexica-an-introduction/). The geography of Mesoamerica is incredibly diverse—it includes humid tropical areas, dry deserts, high mountainous terrain, and low coastal plains. An anthropologist named Paul Kirchhoff first used the term “Mesoamerica” (*meso* is Greek for “middle” or “intermediate”) in 1943 to designate these geographical areas as having shared cultural traits prior to the invasion of Europeans, and the term has remained."

"Typically when we discuss Mesoamerican art we are referring to art made by peoples in Mexico and much of Central America. When people mention Native North American art, they are usually referring to indigenous peoples in the U.S. and Canada, even though these countries are technically all part of North America. More recently, archaeologists and art historians have considered connections between the Southwestern and Southeastern U.S. and Mesoamerica, an area sometimes called either the Greater Southwest or Greater Mesoamerica. Focusing on these connections demonstrates how people were in contact with one another through trade, shared beliefs, migration, or conflict. Ball courts, for instance, are found in Arizona sites such as the Pueblo Grande of the Hohokam. It is important to remember that modern-day geographic terms—like Mesoamerica or the Southwestern U.S.—are recent designations."

Source: Dr. Lauren Kilroy-Ewbank for Khan Academy

View and annotate "History of ancient Mexico, Mesoamerica..." below, which gives us background on the historical and cultural region (consisting mostly of Mexico) known as Mesoamerica. Consider the question: Where does Latinx history begin? Is it here or...?

(13 minutes)



History of ancient Mexico, Mesoamerica 1

Epimetheus



Watch on

(FYI: Mexica is pronounced "Meh-SHEE-kuh" not Méx-i-kuh)

View and annotate the video: "Mesoamerican Mysteries" below. This video extends our exploration of ancient civilizations laying the foundation for our study of Latinx Studies. Pay special attention to art!

(33 Minutes)



Mesoamerican Mysteries: Understanding

Raymond Kresha



Watch on

Why Mesoamerica Matters...

The existence, development, history, and foundation of Mesoamerica matters for our understanding of Latinx origins because it establishes the foundational Indigenous roots of the Americas. Mesoamerica anchors cultural, linguistic, and ancestral identities that continue to shape Latinx communities today. As we learn from the embedded videos, the region was home to highly developed civilizations such as the Maya, Mexica (Aztec), Zapotec, Olmec, and Teotihuacan societies, which created complex systems of government, agriculture, architecture, mathematics, astronomy, trade, and writing independent of European influence.

Understanding Mesoamerica is important to Latinx Studies because many contemporary Latinx identities, cultural practices, foods, languages, spiritual traditions, social values, and even political perspectives trace their origins to these Indigenous civilizations. Corn cultivation, communal traditions, Indigenous cosmologies, and Nahuatl and Maya linguistic influences remain visible throughout Latin America and within Latinx communities in the United States. Mesoamerica therefore provides a historical and cultural foundation that helps explain how Indigenous knowledge and identity survived colonization and continue to shape Latinx experiences today.

This serves as a powerful counter-narrative to Eurocentric histories by demonstrating that the Americas possessed thriving, sophisticated, and independently developed civilizations long before European arrival. Rather than viewing Latinx history as beginning with Spanish conquest or immigration to the United States, Mesoamerica reframes Latinx identity within a much longer history of Indigenous presence, innovation, resistance, and cultural continuity

 Jot down your own thoughts in your notes!